V4.5 HUMANIZED AUDIO GUIDE

Museo Reina Sofía

A room-by-room guide to Spain’s century of modern art — the avant-garde, the Civil War, and Picasso’s Guernica



“Painting is not done to decorate apartments; it is an instrument of war.”

— Pablo Picasso

66 TRACKS · APPROXIMATELY 106 MINUTES · ENGLISH

A walk through Spain’s twentieth century —
from the avant-garde and Guernica to the art of today.

TOUR No. 46

How to use this guide

This is a walk-through audio guide to the Museo Reina Sofía, Spain’s national museum of twentieth-century and contemporary art. It follows the collection from the avant-garde and Picasso’s Guernica on Floor 2, down to the post-war art of Floor 1, and up to the contemporary collection on Floor 4. The guide is built around two kinds of tracks. Knowing the difference will let you move at your own pace.

Room introductions

Most tracks are short room introductions. Play one as you walk into a new room: it tells you what's there, what to look at first, and which works have their own dedicated track. In the header these are marked R-INTRO. They usually run between one and a half and two and a half minutes.

Single-work tracks

The rest focus on a single painting or sculpture. Play one when you are standing in front of the work it describes; in the header these are marked W-FOCUS. They usually run between two and three minutes.

Numbers and room signs

Every track carries a number — 001, 002, and so on — in the order you walk the tour, and the audio files are numbered to match, so you can simply play them in sequence. Where a room number is known it is printed at the top of the track; on Floor 2 these match the gallery’s wall signs. Floors 1 and 4 are mid-rehang (a reinstallation runs to 2028), so there the guide places you by theme rather than by door number — trust the work in front of you.

Pauses and movement

Each track ends with a short silent pause built into the audio. That's your moment to look, photograph if you want to, and walk to the next stop. When you reach a new room, play the next track. When you're standing in front of a marquee work, play its dedicated track. The audio always tells you what to play next at the end of each track. You don't have to remember anything.

On honesty and change

Museums move things — and the Reina Sofía more than most right now. The collection is in the middle of a major reinstallation that runs to 2028, so rooms shift, especially on Floors 1 and 4, and works go off for loan or restoration. The tour names what the museum itself associates with each part of the collection and guides you by sight, but check the live notices at museoreinasofia.es before you go, in case a particular work has moved or is travelling.

The visit, in shape

T00 at the entrance → Floor 2 for the new century and Cubism, the Surrealists, the 1937 Pavilion and Guernica, and the Civil War → down to Floor 1 for the post-war years, the El Paso painters and Basque sculptors, the return of figuration and the art of the Transition → up to Floor 4 for the contemporary collection and the rooftop → T-LAST on the way out. It runs a little over two hours at an unhurried pace.

Contents

66 tracks · approximately 106 minutes of English narration. The first column is the play order, which matches the numbered audio files; the second is the official gallery room. Each track is short enough to listen to standing in front of a work; long enough to give the work its weight.

Opening

001	—	Welcome to the Reina Sofía	ANCHOR	~2 min

Floor 2 · The New Century and Cubism

002	**Floor 2**	The Second Floor: Spain enters the modern age	R-INTRO	~2 min
003	**201**	Picasso, *Woman in Blue*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
004	**201**	José Gutiérrez Solana, *The Gathering at the Café de Pombo*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
005	**202**	Joan Miró, *House with the Palm Tree*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
006	**204**	Cubism, and the art of breaking things open	R-INTRO	~1 min
007	**204**	Juan Gris, *Portrait of Josette*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
008	**204**	María Blanchard, *Cubist composition*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
009	**204**	Pablo Picasso, *Cubist still life*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
010	**204**	Julio González, *iron*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
011	**204**	Pablo Gargallo, *metal mask*	W-FOCUS	~1 min

Floor 2 · The Surrealists

012	**205**	The dream takes over	R-INTRO	~2 min
013	**205**	Salvador Dalí, *The Great Masturbator*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
014	**205**	Salvador Dalí, *Figure at a Window*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
015	**205**	Salvador Dalí, *The Invisible Man*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
016	**205**	Joan Miró, *Painting (Snail, Woman, Flower, Star)*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
017	**205**	Joan Miró, *Portrait II*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
018	**205**	Ángeles Santos, *A World*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
019	**205**	Maruja Mallo, *The Fair*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
020	**205**	Óscar Domínguez, *decalcomania*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
021	**205**	Salvador Dalí, *The Enigma of Hitler*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
022	**Floor 2**	Luis Buñuel & Salvador Dalí, *Un Chien Andalou*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Floor 2 · The 1937 Pavilion and Guernica

023	**206**	Paris, 1937: the Pavilion and the wall it was built around	R-INTRO	~2 min

024	**206**	Picasso, *Guernica*	W-FOCUS	~3 min
025	**206**	Alexander Calder, *Mercury Fountain*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
026	**206**	Julio González, *Montserrat*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
027	**206**	Joan Miró, *The Reaper* (lost)	W-FOCUS	~1 min

Floor 2 · The Civil War

028	**207**	The war, and how it was seen	R-INTRO	~2 min
029	**207**	Robert Capa, *Spanish Civil War photographs*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
030	**207**	Josep Renau, *photomontage*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Floor 1 · After the War

031	**Floor 1**	After the war: a country in grey	R-INTRO	~2 min
032	**Floor 1**	The matter and the scream: Tàpies and El Paso	R-INTRO	~1 min
033	**Floor 1**	Antoni Tàpies, *matter painting*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
034	**Floor 1**	Antonio Saura, *Sagrario*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
035	**Floor 1**	Manolo Millares, *burlap*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
036	**Floor 1**	Rafael Canogar, *The Accident*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
037	**Floor 1**	The Basque sculptors: Chillida and Oteiza	R-INTRO	~2 min
038	**Floor 1**	Eduardo Chillida, *forged iron*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
039	**Floor 1**	Jorge Oteiza, *Homage to Malevich*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
040	**Floor 1**	Martín Chirino, *iron spiral*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
041	**Floor 1**	Cool heads: geometry and the Cuenca group	R-INTRO	~1 min
042	**Floor 1**	Pablo Palazuelo, *geometry*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
043	**Floor 1**	Fernando Zóbel, *lyrical abstraction*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
044	**Floor 1**	Lucio Muñoz, *worked wood*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
045	**Floor 1**	The wider world	R-INTRO	~1 min
046	**Floor 1**	Lucio Fontana, *Spatial Concept*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
047	**Floor 1**	Yves Klein, *blue*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
048	**Floor 1**	Francis Bacon, *Lying Figure*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
049	**Floor 1**	Louise Bourgeois, *cells and spiders*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
050	**Floor 1**	The return of the image	R-INTRO	~1 min
051	**Floor 1**	Antonio López García, *realism*	W-FOCUS	~2 min
052	**Floor 1**	Equipo Crónica, *pop history*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
053	**Floor 1**	Eduardo Arroyo, *political pop*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
054	**Floor 1**	From dictatorship to democracy	R-INTRO	~1 min
055	**Floor 1**	Juan Genovés, *The Embrace*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

056	**Floor 1**	Richard Serra, *Equal-Parallel: Guernica–Bengasi*	W-FOCUS	~2 min

Floor 4 · The Contemporary

057	**Floor 4**	The top floor: the art of the democracy	R-INTRO	~2 min
058	**Floor 4**	Miquel Barceló, *matter and life*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
059	**Floor 4**	Cristina Iglesias, *built nature*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
060	**Floor 4**	Juan Muñoz, *the crowd*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
061	**Floor 4**	Susana Solano, *iron enclosures*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
062	**Floor 4**	The world in the room: international and Latin American art	R-INTRO	~1 min
063	**Floor 4**	Lygia Clark, *Bichos*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
064	**Floor 4**	Pedro Lemebel, *protest and performance*	W-FOCUS	~1 min
065	**Floor 4**	Out onto the roof	R-INTRO	~1 min

Closing

066	**Closing**	Back out into Madrid	CLOSE	~2 min

TRACK 001 ANCHOR 304 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Welcome to the Reina Sofía

Welcome to the Museo Reina Sofía — Spain's national museum of twentieth-century art, and the home of the most famous painting the country has ever produced. You're standing in what was, for two hundred years, a hospital. The long neoclassical block with the deep courtyard is the old San Carlos Hospital, finished in the eighteenth century by Francesco Sabatini, the architect Charles the Third brought from Italy; the patients only moved out in the nineteen-sixties. It reopened as an art centre in 1986, and in 1992 the King and the Queen the museum is named for inaugurated the permanent collection. The glass-and-steel wings with the red lifts came later — the architect Jean Nouvel wrapped a modern building around the old one in 2005.

Here's the shape of what's inside, because it helps to know it before you climb. This is the story of Spain's most turbulent century, told in paint and iron. It begins upstairs on Floor 2 with the great avant-garde — Cubism, Miró, Dalí, the dream of a new art for a new world — and it walks you straight into the catastrophe that broke that dream: the Civil War, and Picasso's *Guernica*. From there the collection carries you through the long grey years of the dictatorship and out the other side, into democracy and the open, restless art of right now.

Two things to know. The museum hangs its collection by theme, not by artist — so Picasso, Miró and Dalí turn up in several rooms, not one each. And the whole collection is being re-hung in a project that runs to 2028, so a few rooms may have shifted since this guide was made. Don't worry about the numbers. I'll keep you oriented by what's in front of you. Take the lift to Floor 2, and let's begin.

TRACK 002 · FLOOR 2 R-INTRO 202 WORDS · ~2 MIN

The Second Floor: Spain enters the modern age

This is the floor most people come for, and it holds the heart of the collection. Everything up here was made roughly between 1900 and the end of the Second World War — the decades when Spanish artists tore up the rulebook and then watched their country tear itself apart. The rooms run in a loop, and they're hung by theme rather than by name, so you'll meet Picasso, Miró and Dalí more than once as the story moves.

It opens quietly, with a young Picasso still finding his feet. Then it gathers speed: Cubism, the language he and Juan Gris built out of broken planes; the Surrealists and their dreams; and then, at the centre of the floor, the room everything has been leading toward — the Spanish Pavilion of 1937 and *Guernica*. After that come the rooms of the Civil War itself.

A word on the light. It's kept low up here, and the rooms are cool — a lot of this work is on paper, and paper is fragile. Bring a layer if you feel the chill. Take your time; this is not a floor to rush. Just along here, in the first rooms, is where it begins.

TRACK 003 · 201 W-FOCUS 281 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Picasso, *Woman in Blue*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the opening rooms of Floor 2, among the earliest works on the floor — a tall portrait of a woman in an enormous ruffled blue dress, her face powdered pale, her eyes fixed somewhere past you.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is *Mujer en azul* — *Woman in Blue* — and Picasso painted it in Madrid in 1901, when he was nineteen. He'd taken a studio in the city and was running the art journal *Arte Joven*, mixing with the writers of the so-called Generation of '98. You can see him trying on influences like coats: the flash of Toulouse-Lautrec in the Parisian showgirl pose, Van Gogh in the colour, and — underneath it all — the long shadow of the Spanish masters down the road at the Prado, El Greco's nervy brushwork and Velázquez's court portraits.

LISTEN FOR

Here's what makes her worth stopping for. Picasso sent this painting to the big National Exhibition of Fine Arts in 1901. It won nothing but a polite honourable mention, and he was so unbothered — already on his way to Paris and his real career — that when the show closed, he simply didn't come back to collect it. The painting vanished into storage for decades. It was only rescued years later by an art historian who recognised what it was, and it passed into the national collection, which is how it ended up here. So you're looking at a masterpiece its own maker walked away from at nineteen — the first chapter of the most influential career in modern art, left behind in a Madrid storeroom. When you've had your fill of her, the route carries on into the Cubist rooms, a few steps on.

TRACK 004 · 201 W-FOCUS 229 WORDS · ~2 MIN

José Gutiérrez Solana, *The Gathering at the Café de Pombo*

WHERE YOU ARE

A large, sombre group portrait in the early rooms — a dozen men in dark coats crowded around a marble café table under a hanging lamp, one of them standing at the centre as if presiding.

WHAT YOU SEE

La tertulia del Café de Pombo, painted by José Gutiérrez Solana in 1920. A *tertulia* is a regular gathering for talk, and the most famous in Madrid met on Saturday nights at the Café de Pombo, near the Puerta del Sol, hosted by the writer Ramón Gómez de la Serna — the figure standing at the centre, holding court. Around him Solana painted the writers and artists of the avant-garde of the day, himself among them, off to one side.

LISTEN FOR

Solana belonged to what's often called *España negra* — black Spain — and you can feel it in the palette: the browns and bruised greys, the slightly cadaverous faces, the gloom that hangs over even this convivial scene. It's a portrait of a whole intellectual world that the coming century would scatter. Cafés like this were the real engines of modern Spanish culture, where the painters and poets you'll meet upstairs argued art into being over coffee and brandy. Within twenty years most of these gatherings would be broken up by war and exile. Solana catches them at the table, mid-conversation, before the lights went out. The Cubist rooms are just ahead.

TRACK 005 · 202 W-FOCUS 222 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Joan Miró, *House with the Palm Tree*

WHERE YOU ARE

An early Miró, and it will surprise you if you only know the later star-and-squiggle work — a crisp, sunlit Catalan farmhouse, every tile and furrow picked out in almost obsessive detail.

WHAT YOU SEE

La casa de la palmera — House with the Palm Tree — from 1918, when Miró was twenty-five and had not yet become "Miró." This is the family farm at Mont-roig, in the countryside south of Barcelona, the place he loved more than anywhere on earth. He painted it in what's called his *detallista* — detailist — manner, giving equal, loving attention to every blade and rooftile, part Catalan folk art, part the new flat colour he'd picked up from the Paris avant-garde.

LISTEN FOR

Hold this in your memory and then go and look at his 1934 painting a few rooms on, the one that's just signs floating on colour. The distance between them is the whole story of how a modern artist is made. Everything in his late work — the love of the Catalan earth, the bright unmixed colour, the sense that a few marks can hold a whole world — is already here, just spelled out in full rather than in shorthand. He spent the rest of his life learning what to leave out. This is the "before." When you're ready, the Cubists are a little further on.

TRACK 006 · 204 R-INTRO 187 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Cubism, and the art of breaking things open

These rooms hold the movement that changed everything. Cubism was invented in Paris, between roughly 1907 and 1914, by Picasso and Georges Braque — two painters who decided you could show an object from several angles at once, shattering it into planes and reassembling it on a flat canvas. It sounds like a parlour trick. It was actually the moment Western art stopped trying to copy the world and started rebuilding it.

The room's other great name is Juan Gris — the third Cubist, a fellow Spaniard in Paris, whose paintings have a cool, crystalline order the others' don't; where Picasso is restless, Gris is exact, almost architectural. And keep an eye out for the iron. Julio González was a Catalan metalworker who taught Picasso how to weld, and then turned welding into sculpture — line drawn directly in steel, with the air left showing through. It's a silent revolution sitting in the middle of the room.

The collection threads these figures through several rooms, so you'll see more of them as you go. When you're ready, the dream-rooms of the Surrealists are next, right along here.

TRACK 007 · 204 W-FOCUS 223 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Juan Gris, *Portrait of Josette*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the Cubist rooms — a portrait of a seated woman built from clean, interlocking planes, far more ordered and legible than the Picassos nearby.

WHAT YOU SEE

Retrato de Josette, painted by Juan Gris in 1916. Josette was his companion, and this is the most important portrait of his career. Gris was the third great Cubist — a Madrid-born painter who followed Picasso to Paris and to the same ramshackle studio building — but his Cubism has a character all its own: where Picasso and Braque shattered things, Gris assembled them, with the cool precision of a man who'd trained as a draughtsman. He called his method the opposite of theirs — they worked from the object toward abstraction; he worked from abstraction back toward the object.

LISTEN FOR

Notice how readable she is. The planes lock together like inlaid wood; the colours are sober and architectural; there's a calm, almost classical balance to the whole thing. Gris brought order to a movement built on disorder, and for that the others slightly looked down on him — and slightly envied him. He died young, at forty, and the Reina Sofía holds several of his finest works, so look around for more. This crystalline clarity is the other face of Cubism, the one that doesn't get put on the posters. The Surrealist rooms are next, through here.

TRACK 008 · 204 W-FOCUS 188 WORDS · ~2 MIN

María Blanchard, *Cubist composition*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the Cubist rooms, near the Gris — a figure built from faceted planes, but warmer and more tender than the men's Cubism around it, the geometry never quite extinguishing the human being inside.

WHAT YOU SEE

María Blanchard, a Cubist of the first rank who has only lately been given her due. Born in Santander in 1881, she lived with a severe physical disability and the cruelty it drew, and she went to Paris and threw herself into Cubism alongside her close friend Juan Gris, Diego Rivera and the sculptor Lipchitz. The Reina Sofía holds her work from the high Cubist years around 1916.

LISTEN FOR

Notice what she does that the others resist — she lets feeling back in. The planes are rigorous, the structure real, but there's a melancholy, an inwardness, that's all her own; soon after this she left strict Cubism behind for tender, sombre paintings of mothers, children and the poor. She belongs with Maruja Mallo and Ángeles Santos upstairs as one of the women this museum is working to move back to the centre of the story. The fractured still lifes of pure Cubism are right here.

TRACK 009 · 204 W-FOCUS 191 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Pablo Picasso, *Cubist still life*

WHERE YOU ARE

A small, dense Cubist canvas in these rooms — a tabletop of objects shattered into brown and grey facets, a guitar or bottle or newspaper just legible inside the fracture.

WHAT YOU SEE

An early Picasso from around 1912, the years when he and Braque were inventing Cubism together in Paris, "roped together like mountaineers," as Braque later put it. The Reina Sofía's early Picassos let you set the teenage realist of *Woman in Blue* downstairs against the revolutionary of a decade later — the same man, having blown the rules apart.

LISTEN FOR

This is the laboratory phase. They'd taken a single object, walked around it in their minds, and laid every viewpoint flat on the one surface at once — top, side, front, all together — so the painting stops being a window and becomes a thing in its own right. Look for the scraps of lettering and the hint of an everyday object; that's the handhold they left you. It's drab on purpose: colour would only distract from the structural revolution. Juan Gris took this language and made it sing; the sculptor Julio González made it stand up in iron — just beyond.

TRACK 010 · 204 W-FOCUS 187 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Julio González, *iron*

WHERE YOU ARE

A spare, open sculpture of welded iron — not a solid mass but a few rods and planes drawing a figure or a head in the air, with as much empty space as metal.

WHAT YOU SEE

Julio González, the Catalan who, more than anyone, invented modern iron sculpture. His family were metalworkers in Barcelona; he learned to forge and weld as a trade, moved to Paris, and in the late 1920s made a historic alliance — he taught his friend Picasso how to weld, and together they opened up a whole new way of making sculpture: not carving or casting, but drawing directly in steel.

LISTEN FOR

That's the phrase to carry — "drawing in space." Instead of a solid body, González gives you the lines of one, with the air left showing through, so the empty space becomes part of the figure. It looks effortless and modern; it rests on a lifetime of real blacksmith's skill. Everything that follows on the floor above — Chillida's forged iron, Oteiza's open boxes — descends from this silent revolution in a Paris workshop. His countryman Gargallo pushed metal another way, round this corner.

TRACK 011 · 204 W-FOCUS 173 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Pablo Gargallo, *metal mask*

WHERE YOU ARE

A sculpture in sheet metal or bronze — often a head or mask — that turns solidity inside out, building a face as much from the hollows and gaps as from the metal itself.

WHAT YOU SEE

Pablo Gargallo, an Aragonese sculptor and a contemporary of González, working the same revolutionary seam: metal as line and void rather than mass. He's famous for masks and heads in hammered copper, lead and iron, in which a curl of metal stands in for a lock of hair and an empty socket does the work of an eye.

LISTEN FOR

The trick that delights everyone is the way absence becomes presence — a hole reads as an eye, a gap as a cheekbone, so your mind completes the face out of nothing. Gargallo kept one foot in classical elegance even as he embraced industrial materials, which gives his work a strange grace the rougher moderns lack. Between him and González, you're watching sculpture step out of stone and into the machine age. The Surrealist rooms are next, a short way on.

TRACK 012 · 205 R-INTRO 202 WORDS · ~2 MIN

The dream takes over

You've come into the Surrealist rooms — and you'll notice the museum asks you not to photograph in here, partly for the works on loan, so let your phone rest and just look. This is where Spanish art goes inward, in the late nineteen-twenties, and follows the dream wherever it leads.

The names you'll meet are the famous ones — Dalí above all — but the surprise of these rooms is how many others were doing extraordinary things at the same moment, and how young most of them were. Several had met as students at the Residencia de Estudiantes in Madrid, the legendary hall of residence where a teenage Dalí shared corridors with the poet Federico García Lorca and the future film-maker Luis Buñuel. What grew out of those friendships — the films, the paintings, the scandals — is half of what hangs here.

Keep two things in mind as you go. First, Surrealism wasn't only about shock; it was a serious attempt to paint the unconscious, the logic of dreams. And second, watch for the women — they were central to this story, and the museum has been working to put them back at its heart. Take it slowly, over here.

TRACK 013 · 205 W-FOCUS 283 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Salvador Dalí, *The Great Masturbator*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the Dalí rooms — a large canvas, soft yellow and pale, dominated by a great drooping head in profile, eyes closed, nose pressed to the ground, with a woman's face rising out of the back of it.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is *El gran masturbador*, painted in 1929 — the most personal painting Dalí ever made, and the one that announced him to the world. That sagging profile is a self-portrait of a kind: its shape is taken directly from a rock formation on the shore at Cap de Creus, near his home in Catalonia, a coastline he knew better than his own face. Out of it spill his obsessions — desire, disgust, shame — pinned to the canvas with a hyper-real precision he'd borrowed from the old masters and turned to brand-new ends.

LISTEN FOR

The date matters. The summer of 1929 was when Dalí met Gala — the Russian émigrée, then married to the poet Paul Éluard — who would become his wife, his manager, and his lifelong obsession. This is the painting of a young man tipping headlong into love and terror at once. Look at the rising female face and the figure below it; look at the grasshopper clinging to the profile, an insect Dalí was genuinely phobic about, and the ants, his lifelong symbol of decay. When he first showed it in Paris that year, a far-right group was so offended they slashed at it. He'd arrived exactly where he wanted to be — at the centre of a scandal. For all the theatre of his later life, this is Dalí before he became a brand: raw, exact, and genuinely strange. When you're ready, his quieter, earlier self is just here.

TRACK 014 · 205 W-FOCUS 241 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Salvador Dalí, *Figure at a Window*

WHERE YOU ARE

Nearby, and a complete change of weather — a calm, tender, almost photographic picture of a young woman seen from behind, leaning on a windowsill, looking out over a still blue bay.

WHAT YOU SEE

Figura en una ventana — Figure at a Window — from 1925, painted in oil on paper when Dalí was just twenty-one, years before the melting clocks and the moustache. The woman is his younger sister, Ana María, who was his favourite model before Gala arrived. The window looks out over the water at Cadaqués, the Catalan fishing village where the family spent its summers, and where Dalí would live for most of his life.

LISTEN FOR

Hold this one next to *The Great Masturbator* hanging a few steps away, and you can see a whole personality in the gap between them. Here there's no provocation at all — just a brother's unhurried attention to his sister, the light on her dress, the patient blue of the bay. It belongs to a long Romantic tradition of figures seen from behind, gazing out — the German painter Caspar David Friedrich did it a century earlier — where the point is that we look with her, not at her. Within a few years Dalí would blow this calm apart and never paint anything this peaceful again. That's why it's worth lingering on: it's the last clear photograph of him before Surrealism, and Gala, and fame rearranged everything. Miró's room is right this way.

TRACK 015 · 205 W-FOCUS 216 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Salvador Dalí, *The Invisible Man*

WHERE YOU ARE

A tall, busy canvas in the Dalí rooms in which, at first, you can't quite see the point — a swarm of figures, ruins, clouds and fragments of landscape that won't settle into a scene.

WHAT YOU SEE

El hombre invisible — The Invisible Man — which Dalí worked on between 1929 and 1932. Keep looking, and a seated human figure slowly assembles itself out of all that clutter: a cloud becomes hair, a waterfall a torso, a ruin a thigh. This was Dalí's first full experiment with what he called the "double image," the cornerstone of his paranoiac-critical method — training the eye to see one thing hidden inside another.

LISTEN FOR

It's deliberately hard work, and that's the point — Dalí wanted you to feel your own mind doing the assembling, flipping between the parts and the whole the way you do with an optical illusion. He took the trick from old masters of disguise like the sixteenth-century painter Arcimboldo, who built faces out of fruit and fish, and pushed it toward the unconscious. He never quite finished this one, which somehow suits it — a picture about a figure that refuses to fully appear, left forever half-emerged. Give your eyes a moment to lock onto the man, then watch him dissolve again. Miró's room is just along here.

TRACK 016 · 205 W-FOCUS 265 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Joan Miró, *Painting (Snail, Woman, Flower, Star)*

WHERE YOU ARE

A wide canvas of flat, glowing colour — soft blues and earth-reds — across which a few simple shapes and a line of hand-painted words seem to float free of gravity.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is Miró's *Pintura* of 1934, usually called by the words written across it — *Snail, Woman, Flower, Star*. By this point Miró had burned away almost everything a painting was supposed to have. No scene, no horizon, no story you could retell — just a private alphabet of signs, a kind of poetry made of shapes, drifting on a coloured ground. He once said he wanted to "assassinate painting," to kill off the polite, decorative version of it, and works like this are him doing exactly that.

LISTEN FOR

Don't try to decode it like a puzzle — that's not how it works. Let your eye wander the way it would over a night sky, picking out a curve here, a star there, the looping handwriting that names the snail and the woman and the flower without ever picturing them. This is the heart of what people mean by "a Miró": the childlike directness that is in fact the product of ferocious discipline, every shape placed with the care of a calligrapher. Look at the date again — 1934. Spain was two years from civil war, and the lightness here would not survive it. The works Miró made for the doomed Republic, a few years and a few rooms on, come out of a much darker place. For now, though, this is the dream at its most weightless. A couple more, not far on.

TRACK 017 · 205 W-FOCUS 193 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Joan Miró, *Portrait II*

WHERE YOU ARE

A small, fierce canvas nearby — a head, more or less, but reduced to a few flat shapes, a couple of staring dots for eyes, set against a flaming red-and-black ground.

WHAT YOU SEE

Retrato II, painted by Miró in 1938 — a world away from the weightless *Snail* of four years earlier. By 1938 Spain was at war and Europe was sliding toward another one, and Miró's work went dark and savage. The playful signs harden here into something almost ferocious: a face stripped down to its rawest components, glaring out of a scorched colour field.

LISTEN FOR

Set it beside the 1934 painting hanging ahead of you and you can watch the temperature of his art drop. Same private alphabet, same flat brilliant colour — but the lightness has curdled into alarm. This is Miró registering catastrophe in the only language he had: not by painting soldiers or ruins, but by letting the shapes themselves grow teeth. It's a reminder that abstraction isn't an escape from history; sometimes it's the most direct record of it we have. Two more women the museum has worked to put back at the centre are a few steps on.

TRACK 018 · 205 W-FOCUS 237 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Ángeles Santos, *A World*

WHERE YOU ARE

A big, strange, unforgettable canvas — a cube of a planet hanging in dark space, with tiny figures, houses and trees clinging to its edges and angels drifting around it. Room 205.

WHAT YOU SEE

Un Mundo — A World — painted in 1929 by Ángeles Santos, who was **eighteen years old** when she made it. Read that again. A teenager, barely trained, produced among the most original Spanish paintings of the entire century: the whole world reimagined as a tilting cube you could fall off the side of, half cosmic vision, half adolescent dread. She showed it at the Autumn Salon in Madrid and it caused a sensation; for a brief moment she was the most talked-about young artist in Spain, befriended by Lorca, compared to the boy-genius poet Rimbaud.

LISTEN FOR

And then, almost as quickly, the story darkened. The pressure of sudden fame, family disapproval, and a breakdown pushed her out of that visionary mode; she lived a long life — she died in 2013, past a hundred — but never painted anything this astonishing again. So you're looking at a kind of comet: one teenager's enormous, lonely vision of the universe, made and then never repeated. The museum has rightly given it pride of place; for years she was a footnote, and she should never have been. Stand with it a moment longer than you planned to. Then, right along here, another woman the textbooks tried to forget.

TRACK 019 · 205 W-FOCUS 239 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Maruja Mallo, *The Fair*

WHERE YOU ARE

A crowded, brilliantly coloured scene of a Madrid street festival — booths and bunting and crowds — but look twice, because the crowd is full of impossible people.

WHAT YOU SEE

La Verbena — The Fair — by Maruja Mallo, from 1927: one of a series she painted of Madrid's popular street parties. At first glance it's pure joy, a snapshot of a summer verbena. Then the details start to misbehave: a one-eyed giant looms over the stalls; a beggar with grotesquely deformed feet shuffles through with a guitar slung on his back. Mallo takes the most ordinary Spanish scene there is and lets the dream leak into it.

LISTEN FOR

Mallo is one of the long-overlooked figures of this museum. She belonged to the brilliant generation around Lorca and Dalí — and she was one of "Las Sinsombrero," the hatless ones, a circle of modern women who once famously took off their hats in the middle of Madrid as a small act of rebellion, and who were largely written out of the history afterwards. She was independent, celebrated in her day, championed by the philosopher Ortega y Gasset, then scattered into exile by the Civil War. For decades her name faded while the men's grew. Standing here, you can see what was almost lost: a painter who could make a street party feel like a vision. The film is next — and for that one, you'll want to sit down. It's close by.

TRACK 020 · 205 W-FOCUS 174 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Óscar Domínguez, *decalcomania*

WHERE YOU ARE

A strange, mottled canvas whose textures look grown rather than painted — spongy, cavernous, vaguely volcanic forms that the eye keeps trying to read as rock, coral or cloud.

WHAT YOU SEE

Óscar Domínguez, the Surrealist from Tenerife, in the Canary Islands, and a master of a chance technique called *decalcomania* — spreading wet paint, pressing another surface onto it, then peeling it away to leave a richly accidental texture that he'd then coax into a landscape or a figure.

LISTEN FOR

It's automatism made physical — the Surrealist dream of letting accident, not the conscious mind, do the inventing. Domínguez would find the image hiding in the random blot, the way you find shapes in clouds, and bring it forward. His best work has a brooding, geological strangeness, full of the volcanic light of his home islands. He lived hard in the Paris Surrealist circle and died by his own hand in 1957; there's a real melancholy under the playful method. Surrealism's most notorious collaboration wasn't a painting at all — it was on a screen, just ahead.

TRACK 021 · 205 W-FOCUS 165 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Salvador Dalí, *The Enigma of Hitler*

WHERE YOU ARE

A bleak, washed-out dreamscape — a vast empty beach under a heavy sky, a dripping telephone, a torn snapshot lying on a plate, a tattered umbrella.

WHAT YOU SEE

El enigma de Hitler, painted by Dalí around 1939, on the eve of the Second World War. The little torn photograph on the plate is of Hitler; the dead telephone, the umbrella — borrowed from the failed peacemaker Chamberlain — and the whole drained, anxious atmosphere make it one of Dalí's strangest and most unsettling pictures.

LISTEN FOR

Dalí claimed it came to him as a premonition, and refused to explain it cleanly — typical of him. His morbid fascination with Hitler scandalised his Surrealist comrades and helped get him expelled from the group; they were anti-fascists, and couldn't stomach his coyness. Whatever he intended, the painting captures a real historical dread — the held breath of Europe in 1939, waiting for catastrophe on an empty beach. Surrealism's most notorious collaboration wasn't a painting at all, a little further on.

TRACK 022 · FLOOR 2 W-FOCUS 240 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Luis Buñuel & Salvador Dalí, *Un Chien Andalou*

WHERE YOU ARE

A small darkened room with a screen, somewhere among the Surrealist galleries. Find a seat; it only runs about sixteen minutes, and it loops.

WHAT YOU SEE

Un Chien Andalou — *An Andalusian Dog* — made in 1929 by two friends from the Residencia de Estudiantes: the film-maker Luis Buñuel and the painter Salvador Dalí. It's the most famous Surrealist film ever made, and it opens with the single most notorious image in cinema — a razor blade drawn across a woman's eye. (Stay for it or look away; you'll know it's coming now.) After that it abandons story altogether: ants pour from a hand, a man drags two grand pianos loaded with dead donkeys and priests across a room, time and place refuse to behave.

LISTEN FOR

The two of them built it, by their own account, by each rejecting any image that "made sense" — they wanted only what arrived unbidden, the logic of a dream with the safety rails removed. It was meant to scandalise the polite Paris avant-garde, and it did; Buñuel claimed he went to the premiere with stones in his pockets in case the audience attacked. Watching it here, surrounded by the paintings, you understand the room you're in differently — these weren't just pictures of dreams; this was a whole generation trying to film the inside of a sleeping head. When you surface, the floor changes mood completely. The Republic is about to go to war, through here.

TRACK 023 · 206 R-INTRO 215 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Paris, 1937: the Pavilion and the wall it was built around

Slow down here. You're walking into the room the whole floor has been building toward, and it helps to know what you're about to see before you see it.

In 1937, Spain was a year into its civil war, and the elected Republic was losing. That spring it did something audacious: it built a pavilion at the World's Fair in Paris — a calm, modern, glass-and-steel box — not to show off, but to plead its case to the world, to say *we are still here, and look what is being done to us.* The government asked Picasso, the most famous living Spaniard, to paint a mural for one of its walls. They gave him the size — it had to fill the wall — and otherwise total freedom.

The rooms here reconstruct that pavilion. Around the one painting you'll find the other works that stood in it: a fountain of running mercury by the American Alexander Calder, a striking figure in sheet iron by Julio González, a lost mural by Miró known now only from photographs. They were all part of the same argument. And then there is the wall itself — the reason this room exists, and the reason this museum exists in the form it does. It's right in front of you.

TRACK 024 · 206 W-FOCUS 323 WORDS · ~3 MIN

Picasso, *Guernica*

WHERE YOU ARE

The long wall of Room 206. You'll know it the moment you turn the corner — almost eight metres of black, white and grey, with a crowd standing silent in front of it. There's no glass, no barrier but a low rope. Stand back far enough to take in the whole wall; it's three and a half metres tall.

WHAT YOU SEE

Guernica, 1937. On the twenty-sixth of April that year, German and Italian warplanes flying for Franco bombed the Basque town of Gernika on a busy market day, for hours, until it burned. When the news and the photographs reached Paris, Picasso — who had been stuck for a subject — found it. He painted this enormous canvas in barely five weeks, in his studio on the Rue des Grands-Augustins, in the greys of newsprint, as if the painting itself were a front page. His companion Dora Maar photographed it as it changed, day by day; those photographs hang nearby.

LISTEN FOR

Everyone goes first to the left — the bull, the screaming horse, the woman holding her dead child. But give the right-hand side its due. There, a figure is falling through a burning building with her arms thrown up, and that is where the painting reaches its true pitch of panic. Look for the broken sword and the small flower in the dead soldier's hand; the lightbulb glaring like an eye at the top; the lamp held out by a ghostly arm, reason trying to see in the dark. Picasso refused to let the painting come home while Franco lived — he said it could only return when Spain was a republic again, when liberties were restored. It waited out the dictatorship in New York. It finally arrived in Madrid in 1981, six years after Franco died. It has not left since. When you can step away — and it takes a few minutes — the rooms of the war itself are close by.

TRACK 025 · 206 W-FOCUS 259 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Alexander Calder, *Mercury Fountain*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the reconstructed Pavilion, not far from *Guernica* — a low metal basin in which a heavy, mirror-bright liquid slides and drips through a series of shallow trays, feeding a thin mobile that quivers at the top. It sits behind protective glass.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is the *Mercury Fountain*, designed in 1937 by the American sculptor Alexander Calder — the only foreigner invited to make work for the Spanish Republic's Pavilion. The Pavilion's architect, Josep Lluís Sert, asked him for something as modern as the Picasso and the Miró it would share the building with, and Calder gave them a fountain that ran not with water but with liquid mercury, tumbling down step by step until it set the little wire mobile trembling.

LISTEN FOR

The mercury was the whole point. It came from the mines at Almadén, in southern Spain — at that moment one of the largest mercury sources on earth, and a town under siege by Franco's forces. So a fountain of running silver metal stood in for a besieged Republican town, a quiet companion-piece to the screaming canvas a few metres away. The original fountain lives now at the Miró foundation in Barcelona, where Calder gave it; what flows here is the museum's reconstruction of it for the rebuilt Pavilion. We know now what they didn't fully grasp then — that mercury vapour is poison — which is why it's sealed behind glass today. Beautiful, toxic, and political to its core: that was the Pavilion in miniature. From here, the rooms turn to the war itself, just beyond.

TRACK 026 · 206 W-FOCUS 190 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Julio González, *Montserrat*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the reconstructed Pavilion near *Guernica* — a figure in sheet iron: a peasant woman standing upright, a child on one arm, her face lifted, a sickle in her hand.

WHAT YOU SEE

La Montserrat, the work Julio González made for the Spanish Republic's Pavilion in 1937 — and a complete change of register from his airy abstract iron. Here he turns realist on purpose: a hard, plain, defiant peasant woman, named for the mountain that is the enduring symbol of his native Catalonia. She is the Republic itself — ordinary, rooted, refusing to bow.

LISTEN FOR

Set her beside *Guernica*. Picasso gave the war its scream; González gave it a figure to stand firm against the scream — endurance rather than agony. The original lives now in a museum in Amsterdam, so what stands in the Pavilion reconstruction here is the museum's reference to it, holding the place she occupied in 1937. That a master of pure abstraction reached, in the emergency, for a plain human figure tells you everything about what that year did to artists. Calder's strange mercury fountain and Miró's lost mural complete the Pavilion — round this corner.

TRACK 027 · 206 W-FOCUS 181 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Joan Miró, *The Reaper* (lost)

WHERE YOU ARE

In the Pavilion display — but look for photographs and documentation rather than a painting, because the work itself no longer exists.

WHAT YOU SEE

El Segador — The Reaper, also called *Catalan Peasant in Revolt* — was the giant mural Joan Miró painted directly onto the Pavilion's staircase wall in 1937. It showed a Catalan peasant, sickle raised, in a blaze of Miró's fierce late-thirties colour: the same defiant rural figure as González's Montserrat, but howling rather than standing still.

LISTEN FOR

And then it vanished. The Pavilion was a temporary building; when the exhibition closed, *The Reaper* — painted on panels that were never properly conserved — was lost, and has never been found. So one of Miró's most political, most important works survives only in black-and-white photographs, like a ghost of the Pavilion. The museum shows that documentation here, which is its own sober lesson: the Republic's great display was dismantled, scattered and partly destroyed, exactly as the Republic itself was. *Guernica* is the one wall that made it home. The rooms of the war itself are next, a short way on.

TRACK 028 · 207 R-INTRO 214 WORDS · ~2 MIN

The war, and how it was seen

These rooms are the reason people sometimes say the Reina Sofía is the closest thing Spain has to a museum of its Civil War. After the hush of *Guernica*, the walls fill with the raw machinery of how that war was fought for hearts and minds — and it's worth slowing down for, because almost none of it is the kind of art you came expecting.

You'll find propaganda posters, many of them startlingly modern in design, made to be pasted on city walls overnight; photographs from the front and from the bombed cities; magazines, pamphlets, the photomontages of artists like Josep Renau, who turned the cut-and-paste techniques of the avant-garde into weapons. Both sides used images, but it's the Republic's that mostly survive here, because this is, in part, the Republic's memorial.

Two things are worth carrying through these rooms. First, how new it all felt — this was one of the first wars fought as much in the press and the cinema as on the ground. And second, how it ends: not in victory, but in defeat, exile, and forty years of silence under Franco. The art on the upper floor is what that silence eventually produced. Before we leave, one photographer deserves a moment of his own — over here.

TRACK 029 · 207 W-FOCUS 217 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Robert Capa, *Spanish Civil War photographs*

WHERE YOU ARE

Among the photographs in the Civil War rooms — small, grainy black-and-white prints that hit harder than anything painted.

WHAT YOU SEE

These are images by Robert Capa, the Hungarian-born photographer who, more than anyone, taught the world what this war looked like. He came to Spain in 1936 with his partner Gerda Taro, also a brilliant photographer, and threw himself at the Republican front lines — close enough that his most famous picture, *The Falling Soldier*, seems to catch a militiaman at the very instant a bullet hits him, arms flung back, rifle slipping from his hand.

LISTEN FOR

That single frame became one of the most famous war photographs ever taken — and among the most argued-over; historians still debate exactly when and how it was made, and whether it shows what it appears to show. Capa went on to define modern war photography and to coin its hardest rule — that if your pictures aren't good enough, you weren't close enough — before being killed by a landmine in Indochina in 1954. Taro had died in Spain years earlier, crushed during the retreat from a battle. Stand with these prints a moment. They're where the twentieth century learned to see its own wars in close-up. Now we'll leave the war behind, and make our way to Floor 1.

TRACK 030 · 207 W-FOCUS 190 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Josep Renau, *photomontage*

WHERE YOU ARE

Among the war material — bold, graphic posters and photomontages, sharper and more modern than anything painted, made to be read across a street.

WHAT YOU SEE

Josep Renau, the Valencian artist who became the Republic's master of propaganda design. He took the avant-garde technique of photomontage — cutting and recombining photographs — and turned it into a weapon, producing posters on hunger, fascism, the defence of Madrid and the education of the people, in punchy reds and blacks with slicing diagonals.

LISTEN FOR

Renau was, in fact, the Republican official who commissioned *Guernica* from Picasso for the Pavilion — so he sits at the very centre of this museum's story. His montages show the other face of wartime art: not the anguished masterpiece, but the cheap, fast, mass-produced image meant to move a population to act. He paid for his loyalty with exile, ending up in Mexico and then East Germany. Look at how modern these still feel — the design language of the whole twentieth century is already here, pressed into the service of a desperate cause. Now we'll leave the war behind and make our way down to Floor 1, just here.

TRACK 031 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 209 WORDS · ~2 MIN

After the war: a country in grey

Make your way to Floor 1 — and brace for a change of mood. If the second floor was about a country dreaming, this floor is about a country surviving. The work here mostly comes from the long decades after the Civil War, under Franco's dictatorship, when the Republic had lost, the avant-garde was scattered into exile, and a heavy silence settled over Spanish culture.

One honest warning before we start. This part of the collection is in the middle of a years-long re-hang that runs to 2028, so the rooms up here shift more than the ones downstairs. I'll guide you by theme rather than by door number; trust what's on the wall in front of you over any number you see.

What you're looking for falls into two big responses to that grey time. One is abstraction — artists who couldn't say anything openly, so they said everything through raw matter and gesture, in work that slips past the censor because it names nothing. The other, later, is the slow return of recognisable images, and finally the art of the Transition, when Franco died and Spain edged back toward democracy. We'll end on the floor with two of the most charged objects in the building. This way.

TRACK 032 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 185 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The matter and the scream: Tàpies and El Paso

The first thing to find is the abstraction that came out of the nineteen-fifties — and you'll feel it before you read a single label, because so much of it looks wounded.

The presiding figure is Antoni Tàpies, a Catalan who turned the humble wall into his subject. Around him, look for the group called El Paso — "the step" — founded in Madrid in 1957: Antonio Saura's furious black-and-white figures, Manolo Millares's torn and knotted sackcloth, Rafael Canogar's raw gestures. They had almost nothing in common stylistically, but they shared a conviction — that after the catastrophe, beauty was a lie, and only raw matter told the truth.

None of it is comfortable. None of it was meant to be. Under a censorship that watched every recognisable image, abstraction became a loophole: a painting that names nothing can't be accused of saying anything, yet these scarred surfaces say a great deal. It was protest that learned to speak in a language the regime couldn't quite read. Let's look at four of them in turn, beginning with the master of the wall, right this way.

TRACK 033 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 210 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Antoni Tàpies, *matter painting*

WHERE YOU ARE

A large surface that barely looks like a painting at all — thick, grey, scarred, more like a slab of plastered wall pulled off a building than anything hung in a gallery. The Reina Sofía owns Tàpies in real depth, so you may find several.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is the signature mode of Antoni Tàpies, the foremost Catalan painter of *matèria* — matter. He mixed marble dust, sand, clay and varnish into a heavy paste, troweled it onto the canvas, then scratched, gouged, scored and stamped it: crosses, footprints, numbers, the letter T for Tàpies, and for Teresa, his wife. The Catalan word *tàpies* even means "walls."

LISTEN FOR

That's the key that unlocks him. He grew up in Barcelona under Franco, in a city whose walls carried everything — political graffiti, bullet scars, torn posters, the marks of a population that couldn't speak freely. He turned the wall itself into his canvas: mute, weathered, covered in the half-erased signs of people who passed by and left a mark. Stand close and read it like a surface in the street rather than a picture on a wall — a scratch, a smear, a cross — and it stops being abstract and starts being a record. The fury of El Paso is just along here.

TRACK 034 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 192 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Antonio Saura, *Sagrario*

WHERE YOU ARE

A violent black-and-white canvas — a single figure, or a face, slashed and smeared into being with what looks like pure rage, the brushwork almost attacking the surface.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is Antonio Saura, the most ferocious of the El Paso painters, and *Sagrario* dates from 1960. Saura worked almost entirely in black, white and grey, building portraits, crucifixions and women out of furious, looping strokes that twist the face into something between a scream and a smear. The titles are often calm — a name, a saint, a lady — which only makes the violence on the canvas land harder.

LISTEN FOR

Saura adored Goya and Velázquez, and you can feel the lineage — this is the same Spanish darkness that runs through Goya's black paintings, dragged into the age of abstraction. He's not painting a person so much as the act of destroying and rebuilding one, again and again. In a country where you couldn't paint the dictator, you could paint this: a human form coming apart under pressure. Look at how the white fights the black for the surface. Then Millares, who took the same fury and made it three-dimensional, not far on.

TRACK 035 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 189 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Manolo Millares, *burlap*

WHERE YOU ARE

Not really a painting and not quite a sculpture — a piece of coarse sackcloth, torn, knotted, stitched and stretched, stained black and white, with holes that open onto darkness behind.

WHAT YOU SEE

Manolo Millares, another founder of El Paso, made his art out of *arpillera* — burlap, the cheap sacking used for potatoes and sand. He'd rip it, knot it, sew it back together with rough twine, and let it sag and bulge off the frame, then work it in black and white. He came from the Canary Islands, and the bound, bandaged forms carry an echo of the mummies in the islands' museums that fascinated him as a boy.

LISTEN FOR

Think of these as wounds, or bodies, or shrouds — Millares wanted exactly that ambiguity. After a war and under a dictatorship, he made art that looks like something damaged and clumsily patched, beautiful and disturbing at once. The holes matter as much as the cloth: he's letting the darkness show through. It's the most physical art on this floor — protest you could almost touch. The Basque sculptors took the same questions into iron and stone, ahead of you.

TRACK 036 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 163 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Rafael Canogar, *The Accident*

WHERE YOU ARE

A stark canvas — a sprawled human figure seen from above, painted in heavy blacks, greys and dirty whites, half-abstract, half-horribly recognisable.

WHAT YOU SEE

Rafael Canogar, the youngest of the El Paso founders, and a piece like *El accidente* of 1963. Canogar began as a pure abstract gesturalist, then did something the others mostly didn't — he let the figure back in, painting bodies that look like news photographs of beatings, accidents and the repressed: social reality forced up through the abstraction.

LISTEN FOR

That move matters. As the 1960s wore on, gesture alone started to feel evasive to some of these painters — too easy to admire as decoration. Canogar dragged the human body back onto the canvas to make the violence unmistakable, a bridge between El Paso's abstraction and the political figuration that came next. The flattened, fallen figure is deliberately hard to place: victim, protester, ordinary citizen, you. The Basque sculptors took the same charged energy into iron and stone, a few steps on.

TRACK 037 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 188 WORDS · ~2 MIN

The Basque sculptors: Chillida and Oteiza

Two names dominate Spanish sculpture of these years, and they came from the same small corner of the Basque Country — close enough to be rivals, and they were.

Eduardo Chillida worked iron the way a poet works words: heavy forged beams that reach out and curl back, holding empty space inside their grip. Trained first as an architect, he was forever interested in what the gap, the air, the wind did to the metal around it; his great combs of steel out on the Atlantic at San Sebastián are the famous example, but even the smaller pieces here carry that sense of weight cradling emptiness.

Jorge Oteiza went at the same problem from the opposite side. Where Chillida added, Oteiza subtracted — hollowing his forms out until what's left is mostly the void, the absence, the boxes he called "metaphysical." He more or less argued himself out of making sculpture altogether, deciding he'd proved his point. Stand between the two of them and you're watching a real conversation about the same question — what is emptiness worth? — answered in opposite directions. Chillida first, right along here.

TRACK 038 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 191 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Eduardo Chillida, *forged iron*

WHERE YOU ARE

A piece of heavy dark iron or weathered steel — bars and blades that bend, hook and reach into the air around them, sitting with enormous grave weight.

WHAT YOU SEE

Eduardo Chillida, the Basque master, who started as a footballer, trained as an architect, and then gave his life to the question of space. The museum holds his work across the decades — from an early carved torso of 1948 to the great CORTEN-steel tables of the 1980s, one a homage to Goethe, who died begging for "more light." He forged iron at the anvil like a blacksmith, and the forms always seem to be doing something to the air: gripping it, framing it, sheltering it.

LISTEN FOR

Don't just look at the metal — look at the space it holds. That's the whole point of Chillida: the emptiness inside the iron is as much the sculpture as the iron itself. He spoke about the wind and the sea and light as his real materials. Walk around it slowly and watch the gaps open and close as you move. His rival in the next breath, Oteiza, took that idea to its extreme — close by.

TRACK 039 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 183 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Jorge Oteiza, *Homage to Malevich*

WHERE YOU ARE

A small, austere construction — a cube or box of metal, opened up and hollowed out, so that the empty interior is clearly the subject and the metal is just its edges.

WHAT YOU SEE

Jorge Oteiza, Chillida's great rival, and a piece like his *Homage to Malevich* of the late 1950s. Oteiza spent years on what he called his "experimental purpose": a systematic emptying-out of sculpture, removing mass until only structured void remained. Then, having decided he'd solved sculpture, he largely stopped — and turned to poetry, theory and furious public argument instead.

LISTEN FOR

The homage in the title is to the Russian Kazimir Malevich, who'd tried to reach zero in painting with his black square; Oteiza wanted to reach zero in three dimensions. So look at the holes, not the metal. He believed an empty, opened form could be spiritually active — a kind of shelter for the spirit, he said. It's cerebral, stubborn, and oddly moving once you stop waiting for it to be a "thing" and start seeing the nothing it frames. A few more abstractionists, then the world beyond Spain, just ahead.

TRACK 040 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 165 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Martín Chirino, *iron spiral*

WHERE YOU ARE

A piece of black forged iron coiled into a spiral or a curl, like a gust of wind or a wave caught and frozen in metal.

WHAT YOU SEE

Martín Chirino, from the Canary Islands, an El Paso member and, with Chillida and Oteiza, one of the pre-eminent Spanish iron sculptors. His lifelong motif is the spiral — the "wind," the *espiral del viento* — drawn from the swirling Atlantic winds of his islands and from the ancient spiral carvings of their first inhabitants, the Guanches.

LISTEN FOR

Where Chillida grips space and Oteiza empties it, Chirino sets it spinning. He forged the iron himself at the anvil, so the metal keeps the memory of the hammer, and the spiral form feels alive — uncoiling, breathing, never quite still. It ties the cool intellect of modern sculpture back to something very old and very local: the wind over a volcanic island, marked in rock thousands of years ago. The cooler, more lyrical strain of abstraction is a little further on.

TRACK 041 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 154 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Cool heads: geometry and the Cuenca group

Not all the abstraction of these years was a scream. Alongside the matter and the fury ran a cooler, more lyrical line — artists who reached for order, geometry and silence rather than raw emotion.

The standout is Pablo Palazuelo, a near-mystic of geometry, who built quiet, crystalline structures of line and muted colour that feel closer to music or mathematics than to the wounded surfaces next door. And look for the artists of the so-called Cuenca group — Fernando Zóbel, Gustavo Torner, Gerardo Rueda — who in the 1960s founded a little museum of abstract art in the hanging houses of the old town of Cuenca, and made delicate, contemplative work in dialogue with one another.

Together they're a reminder that "post-war Spanish abstraction" wasn't one thing. Some artists howled; others withdrew into a pure, ordered calm — two ways of stepping outside a reality you couldn't change. Palazuelo's geometry is through here.

TRACK 042 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 178 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Pablo Palazuelo, *geometry*

WHERE YOU ARE

A canvas or a slim metal sculpture of interlocking lines and angular shapes — restrained, precise, in deep muted colour, with the calm of a diagram and the feel of a piece of music.

WHAT YOU SEE

Pablo Palazuelo, the solitary master of Spanish geometric abstraction. The museum holds him from the 1950s — works with titles like *Solitudes* — through to later pieces like *Sylvarum* of the 1980s. Trained partly as an architect in England, he came to believe that geometry was a living, generative force — that a line, followed honestly, would grow and branch according to its own hidden law, the way a crystal or a plant does.

LISTEN FOR

So don't read these as cold design. Palazuelo thought of them as organisms — forms unfolding, almost growing, from a single seed of line. He was deeply read in alchemy, music and Eastern thought, and the work has that meditative charge: it asks you to slow down and follow the lines rather than take in the shape at a glance. After the calm, the wider world arrives — just beyond.

TRACK 043 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 166 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Fernando Zóbel, *lyrical abstraction*

WHERE YOU ARE

A pale, contemplative canvas — fields of soft grey and white veiled in mist, with a few fine, precise dark lines drawn across them like calligraphy or the trace of a thought.

WHAT YOU SEE

Fernando Zóbel, a Spanish-Filipino painter of rare refinement and the founding spirit of that little museum of abstract art in the hanging houses of Cuenca. He'd lay down delicate washes of grey, then inject single hair-fine lines with a syringe, so the gesture floats over the haze with extraordinary control.

LISTEN FOR

If the El Paso painters were a shout, Zóbel is a held breath. His abstraction is all distance, silence and exactness — closer to Chinese landscape painting or to music than to Western expressionism. He was a great collector and teacher as much as a painter, and gathering his Cuenca circle into one museum was itself a small act of resistance: making space for contemplation in a noisy, narrow time. His countryman Lucio Muñoz worked the opposite way, in rough matter, round this corner.

TRACK 044 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 150 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Lucio Muñoz, *worked wood*

WHERE YOU ARE

A large surface that isn't canvas at all but wood — gouged, carved, burned and painted, so the picture is dug into a physical relief.

WHAT YOU SEE

Lucio Muñoz, a Madrid abstractionist who made his characteristic work on *tablex* — hardboard — which he carved, gouged and scorched into rugged, cave-like reliefs before staining them in earthy colour. The result sits between painting and sculpture, like a weathered wall or a furrowed landscape.

LISTEN FOR

He belongs to the same matter-minded generation as Tàpies and Millares — the conviction that raw, worked material says more after a war than smooth illusion ever could. But Muñoz's surfaces feel geological rather than wounded: ridges, hollows and grottoes you could imagine light moving across. Stand to one side and watch the carved relief throw its own shadows. The cool, lyrical strain of abstraction gives way now to the return of the recognisable world, a short way on.

TRACK 045 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 148 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The wider world

Spain didn't make this art in a vacuum, and the museum threads the major international currents of the post-war decades through these floors so you can see the conversation.

Look for the Italian Lucio Fontana, who took a knife to the canvas itself; for the Frenchman Yves Klein and his single, saturated, patented blue; for the raw figures of the Briton Francis Bacon; and, scattered through the collection, for Arte Povera from Italy, Neo-Concrete art from Brazil, and the experimental edges of Latin American art that the Reina Sofía has worked hard to bring into the story. It's a deliberately broad, deliberately international picture — the museum's argument that Spanish modernism belongs inside a global one, not in a national box.

Two of these outsiders are worth stopping for in particular: an Italian who attacked the canvas, and a Briton who attacked the body. Fontana first, over here.

TRACK 046 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 174 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Lucio Fontana, *Spatial Concept*

WHERE YOU ARE

A monochrome canvas — often a single flat colour — with clean slashes or punctures cut straight through it, opening the surface onto the shadow behind.

WHAT YOU SEE

Lucio Fontana, the Italian-Argentine founder of what he called *Spazialismo* — Spatialism — and his *Concetto spaziale*, "Spatial Concept." The radical move sounds simple and was anything but: he stopped painting *on* the canvas and started cutting *through* it, slicing it with a blade or piercing it with holes, so the work reached into real space behind the flat surface.

LISTEN FOR

It looks like vandalism and is actually the opposite — a calm, deliberate philosophical act. For centuries a canvas was a window pretending to be deep; Fontana ended the pretence by making the depth literal, letting the dark behind the cloth become part of the work. Resist the urge to peer through the cut; just register the shock of it — the violence of the gesture against the serenity of the empty colour. It changed what a painting could be. The Briton Francis Bacon is just here.

TRACK 047 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 154 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Yves Klein, *blue*

WHERE YOU ARE

A canvas, or a sponge relief, soaked in a single, almost unreal ultramarine blue so deep and even it seems to hum.

WHAT YOU SEE

Yves Klein, the French provocateur of Nouveau Réalisme, and his signature International Klein Blue — a pigment so saturated he patented the formula. He believed this one blue could open onto pure space, the infinite, the void, and he used it on everything: flat monochromes, sponges, even, notoriously, bodies pressed onto canvas.

LISTEN FOR

Stand close enough that the blue fills your vision and you'll feel what he was after — not a picture of anything, but an immersion, colour as a door out of the material world. Klein was half mystic, half showman, and dead at thirty-four, but this blue outlived him as one of the few colours in art history that belongs to a single name. After Fontana's cut and Klein's void, the most bodily painter of all waits right this way.

TRACK 048 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 221 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Francis Bacon, *Lying Figure*

WHERE YOU ARE

A single, unmistakable canvas — a lone human figure, distorted almost to meat, slumped or sprawled on a bare structure inside a flat, airless field of colour.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is the museum's one major Francis Bacon, a *Lying Figure* from the 1960s. Bacon was the supreme British painter of the body in extremis — not the wounded body of war, but the everyday horror of simply being flesh, alone, in a room. He worked from photographs and memory rather than from a live model, smearing and twisting the face and limbs until the figure seems caught mid-spasm, then set them in cool, hard-edged spaces that only sharpen the violence.

LISTEN FOR

It's worth asking why this hangs here, in a museum so bound up with Spain's own history. Bacon revered the Spanish masters — Velázquez above all, whose screaming pope he reworked obsessively — and his caged, howling figures are a direct descendant of the tradition that runs through Goya's black paintings up the road at the Prado. So this lone foreigner isn't really an outsider; he's the international face of a very Spanish obsession with the suffering body. After the political wounds of the floors below, Bacon makes it private — just a person, in a room, with no war to blame. Now Spain reaches for the recognisable world again, just along here.

TRACK 049 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 162 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Louise Bourgeois, *cells and spiders*

WHERE YOU ARE

Something that unsettles before you understand it — perhaps a caged "cell" of objects, a stitched figure, or the leg of a great spider.

WHAT YOU SEE

Louise Bourgeois, the French-American artist who, across a career of almost eighty years, turned private memory, the body and the family into among the most powerful bodies of work of the century. The museum holds her among its international voices. Her spiders she called *Maman* — mother — a tribute, not a horror: her mother was a weaver, patient and protective. Her caged "Cells" trap furniture, clothing and fragments into chambers of memory you can only peer into.

LISTEN FOR

Bourgeois made art as a way of surviving her own childhood, and she's unflinching about it — desire, jealousy, fear, repair, all of it stitched and caged and cast. The work looks psychological because it is; she said sculpture let her give shape to feelings she couldn't otherwise hold. Now Spain reaches for the recognisable world again, not far on.

TRACK 050 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 163 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The return of the image

Not everyone went abstract. Alongside the matter and the gesture, a counter-current ran through these years: artists who insisted on the recognisable world, often as their own private form of resistance.

The towering figure is Antonio López García, Spain's great realist, who paints Madrid — a sink, a quince tree, a street at dawn — so slowly and so exactly that a single canvas can take him years; the patience itself feels like a moral position. Look too for Equipo Crónica, a duo who raided the Prado's own masterpieces — Velázquez, Goya — and spliced them with comic-strip flatness and pop colour to make sharp, sly comments on Spain under Franco. And for the cooler, stranger figuration of Luis Gordillo. Between them and the abstractionists next door you're seeing two ways of surviving the same silence: one that dissolved the world into matter, and one that described it so precisely you couldn't pretend not to see it. Antonio López first, ahead of you.

TRACK 051 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 192 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Antonio López García, *realism*

WHERE YOU ARE

A painting of something utterly ordinary — a kitchen sink, a half-eaten meal, a bare Madrid street at first light — rendered with a patience and precision that stop you in your tracks.

WHAT YOU SEE

Antonio López García, Spain's greatest living realist. He paints the commonplace — his family, his bathroom, the view down the Gran Vía at dawn — with a slowness that is almost legendary; some canvases occupy him for ten or twenty years, returning to the same spot at the same hour, year after year, to catch the exact light.

LISTEN FOR

This is realism as devotion, not nostalgia. While his contemporaries tore paintings apart, López did the hardest thing of all — he looked, and kept looking, at the world as it is. There's a strange melancholy in it: the light is real, the moment is true, and you can feel how much time is buried in the paint. He became famous far beyond art circles thanks to a film about him trying, and failing, to finish painting a quince tree before its fruit ripened and fell. Equipo Crónica turned figuration the other way — toward irony — a few steps on.

TRACK 052 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 179 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Equipo Crónica, *pop history*

WHERE YOU ARE

A bright, flat, almost cartoon-like canvas in which figures you half-recognise from the Prado — Velázquez's princess, Goya's firing squad — collide with comic-strip colour and modern intrusions.

WHAT YOU SEE

Equipo Crónica — "Chronicle Team" — was a partnership of two Valencian painters, Rafael Solbes and Manuel Valdés, working together from the mid-1960s. They took the language of Pop Art and aimed it squarely at Spanish history and the Franco regime, raiding the masterpieces of the Prado and recasting them in flat, poster-bright style, full of sly anachronism and political bite.

LISTEN FOR

The trick is the double-take. You recognise *Las Meninas* or the *Third of May*, and then you notice what's been changed, added, or made absurd — and the joke turns sharp. Under a censorship that watched everything, humour and quotation were weapons: you could say the unsayable if you said it through Velázquez. It's the wittiest art on this floor, and the angriest underneath the wit. From here the collection moves to the moment everything changed — the death of the dictator, and the Transition — right along here.

TRACK 053 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 160 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Eduardo Arroyo, *political pop*

WHERE YOU ARE

A flat, bold, almost poster-like canvas, sharp-edged and biting, often skewering a recognisable figure of power or a cliché of Spanish identity.

WHAT YOU SEE

Eduardo Arroyo, the sharpest satirist of Spanish painting, who spent much of the Franco years in exile in Paris because his work was too pointed to show at home. He used the clean, flat language of Pop and narrative figuration as a scalpel — mocking the dictatorship, the bullfight, the tourist-poster version of Spain, and the pieties of the art world itself.

LISTEN FOR

Arroyo is the wit to set against the wounds elsewhere on this floor — he fights with irony rather than anguish. The targets are specific and the jokes are sharp, but underneath is real anger at a country forced into a costume. He shares the political bite of Equipo Crónica nearby; they were all weaponising the cool surfaces of Pop against a regime that couldn't take a joke. The art of the Transition is close by.

TRACK 054 · FLOOR 1 R-INTRO 149 WORDS · ~1 MIN

From dictatorship to democracy

Slow down for the last stretch of this floor, because it carries more political weight than anything else in the building except *Guernica* itself.

Franco died in November 1975, and Spain began the fragile, dangerous passage that Spaniards simply call *la Transición* — the Transition — from dictatorship back to democracy. The museum has built a gallery around those years, opened in 2025 as part of the country's official marking of fifty years of freedom. It gathers the art made in the thick of that uncertainty — when nobody yet knew whether the country would reconcile or fall back into violence.

At its heart is a single, deceptively simple painting that became the emblem of the whole era, and beside it, a steel sculpture that ties this museum's newest history back to its oldest wound. They're the right place to end this floor. The painting first — just ahead.

TRACK 055 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 275 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Juan Genovés, *The Embrace*

WHERE YOU ARE

In the gallery devoted to the Transition. Look for a painting seen as if from above: a crowd of plain, faceless figures rushing together into one another's arms.

WHAT YOU SEE

This is *El abrazo* — *The Embrace* — painted by Juan Genovés in 1976, the year after Franco died. Genovés was a committed political painter, and in 1976 the clandestine democratic opposition asked him for an image to campaign for an amnesty for political prisoners. He gave them this: ordinary people, backs and limbs only, no faces at all, flinging themselves into a collective embrace. By stripping away every individual feature he made it belong to everyone — a whole country longing to forgive and be forgiven.

LISTEN FOR

It became *the* image of the Transition. It was turned into an Amnesty International poster, and printing it got Genovés himself arrested and jailed for a week. And it's bound up with one of the darkest nights of those years — in January 1977, far-right gunmen murdered a group of labour lawyers in their office on the Calle de Atocha, just up the road; a reproduction of this very painting hung on their wall. A sculpture based on it now stands near the spot. For decades the original sat in the museum's basement, brought out only occasionally; the painter felt it belonged to all democrats, not to a store-room. It was finally given pride of place, and in 2025 it became the centrepiece of the new Transition gallery, as Spain marked fifty years since the dictatorship ended. Few paintings carry this much of a nation's hope. The last work on this floor is very different — a little further on.

TRACK 056 · FLOOR 1 W-FOCUS 292 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Richard Serra, *Equal-Parallel: Guernica–Bengasi*

WHERE YOU ARE

A room given over to four enormous blocks of rust-brown steel, set on the floor in an alternating arrangement with an empty space at the centre. Walk around and between them — that's the point.

WHAT YOU SEE

Equal-Parallel: Guernica–Bengasi, made by the American sculptor Richard Serra in 1986. Four solid slabs of weathering steel — two squares, two rectangles — each raised to about a metre and a half, the exact height of the windowsills in the room. Serra usually insisted his work referred to nothing but itself, to weight and space and your own body moving through it. This piece is his one exception: the title yokes together two bombings of civilians — Guernica in 1937, and the United States Air Force's attack on Benghazi in Libya in April 1986, the very month he was making it.

LISTEN FOR

It was built specifically for this museum, for the 1986 exhibition that opened the Reina Sofía as an art centre. And then it became the subject of one of the strangest scandals in museum history. After the show it went into storage — and somewhere over the following years, it was simply lost. In 2006 the museum was forced to admit it had mislaid a thirty-eight-tonne steel sculpture: the storage firm had gone under, and nobody could say where the slabs had gone. What you're walking around is the replica Serra made to replace the vanished original. So this is a work about two erasures — two cities bombed off the map — that then, impossibly, erased itself. Stand in the empty centre for a second and let that sink in. When you're ready, there's one more floor — the newest art in the building — up at the top. This way to the lift.

TRACK 057 · FLOOR 4 R-INTRO 204 WORDS · ~2 MIN

The top floor: the art of the democracy

One more climb, to the top of the Sabatini building, and into the present. Floor 4 holds the contemporary collection — the art of Spain from roughly 1975, the year Franco died, all the way to now. After everything you've walked through downstairs, this floor feels like a held breath being let out.

The late seventies and eighties were Spain's great exhale — the years of *la Movida*, the explosion of freedom and colour and noise that followed the dictatorship, when Madrid stayed up all night and artists tore into every style at once. Out of it came a generation that finally rejoined the international art world as equals: painters like Miquel Barceló, sculptors and installation-makers like Cristina Iglesias and Juan Muñoz, set among foreign and Latin-American voices the museum has deliberately woven in.

I'll be honest with you here, more than anywhere: this is the floor most in flux. It's the front line of a re-hang that runs to 2028, and contemporary collections rotate fast by nature. So treat the next few stops as the kinds of thing you'll meet rather than a fixed checklist, read the room sheets, and follow what catches you. A few artists worth seeking out, through here.

TRACK 058 · FLOOR 4 W-FOCUS 177 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Miquel Barceló, *matter and life*

WHERE YOU ARE

A large, heavily worked canvas that almost bulges off the wall — thick crusts of paint, often earth-coloured, sometimes scattered with what look like real organic traces: fruit, fish, the residue of a meal or a sea floor.

WHAT YOU SEE

Miquel Barceló, born in Mallorca in 1957, the leading Spanish painter to emerge from the *Movida* years and the first of his generation to win real international fame. He builds his surfaces up into near-relief, mixing pigment with sand, soil and organic matter, so the painting becomes a kind of living, decaying landscape you could almost dig into.

LISTEN FOR

Barceló paints what he lives among — the dry Mallorcan earth, the Mediterranean sea-bed, and later the light and termite-mounds of West Africa, where he spent long stretches. There's a direct line back to Tàpies downstairs in all that matter, but where Tàpies's walls are grave and grey, Barceló's teem — with heat, decay, abundance, life. Stand back and it's a landscape; step close and it's a crust of stuff caught mid-transformation. Two sculptors who reshaped Spanish space are just beyond.

TRACK 059 · FLOOR 4 W-FOCUS 184 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Cristina Iglesias, *built nature*

WHERE YOU ARE

An installation rather than an object — perhaps a hanging canopy or a screen of woven, vegetal-looking material, or a chamber you can step toward, often casting intricate latticed shadows.

WHAT YOU SEE

Cristina Iglesias, born in San Sebastián in 1956 and among the most admired sculptors Spain has produced since the war. She makes spaces rather than statues — suspended ceilings, walls of cast foliage, passageways and wells — in materials like resin, bronze, woven esparto and water, that blur the line between architecture and nature, the built and the grown.

LISTEN FOR

Her work plays a subtle trick on you. What reads as dense vegetation turns out to be carefully cast and constructed; what looks like a natural grotto is engineered to the millimetre. She's fascinated by thresholds — the canopy you stand under, the screen you can't quite see through, the water you can't reach — so the experience is always about your own body, waiting at an edge. It's the inheritance of Chillida and Oteiza's obsession with space, carried into a new generation. Juan Muñoz, who filled space with unsettling figures, is round this corner.

TRACK 060 · FLOOR 4 W-FOCUS 173 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Juan Muñoz, *the crowd*

WHERE YOU ARE

Figures — small, grey, oddly featureless human forms, often grouped, sometimes laughing, sometimes balanced on impossible perches — that you come upon as if you'd interrupted them.

WHAT YOU SEE

Juan Muñoz, born in Madrid in 1953 and lost far too early in 2001, was a foremost Spanish sculptor of the uncanny human presence. He filled rooms with grey resin figures — his "conversation pieces" — caught mid-gesture, mid-laugh, mid-something, never quite acknowledging you, so that you become the intruder in a scene whose meaning you've just missed.

LISTEN FOR

The unease is deliberate and beautifully judged. The figures are almost identical, almost faceless, often slightly too small, and they relate to one another and to the architecture but never to you — and that exclusion is the whole feeling. He was a storyteller without a story, building theatrical spaces of silence and isolation. He died suddenly at forty-eight, just as the world fully recognised him; the loss still shadows Spanish art. Beyond these names, the floor opens out to the wider world — a short way on.

TRACK 061 · FLOOR 4 W-FOCUS 138 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Susana Solano, *iron enclosures*

WHERE YOU ARE

A large sculpture in iron and steel mesh — a cage, a tank, an enclosure you can look into but not enter, austere and discreetly forbidding.

WHAT YOU SEE

Susana Solano, born in Barcelona in 1946, one of the major Spanish sculptors of the generation after Chillida and Oteiza, and for years among the most internationally respected. She works in industrial iron, lead and wire mesh, building containers and enclosures — spaces that are sealed, screened or barred.

LISTEN FOR

The feeling is always about inside and outside, protection and exclusion. You can see through the mesh but not pass; the space is offered and withheld at once. She inherits the Basque sculptors' obsession with what emptiness can hold, and gives it a cooler, more architectural, faintly anxious edge — the void as something guarded. The museum's reach beyond Spain is over here.

TRACK 062 · FLOOR 4 R-INTRO 171 WORDS · ~1 MIN

The world in the room: international and Latin American art

The contemporary floor is also where the Reina Sofía makes its boldest argument — that it is not a museum of Spanish art that occasionally borrows from abroad, but a museum of modern and contemporary art with a particular, deliberate tilt toward Latin America and the global South.

So among the Spaniards you'll find international heavyweights — Louise Bourgeois, Bruce Nauman, the conceptual and minimal currents of the later twentieth century — set alongside Brazilian Neo-Concrete art like Lygia Clark, Italian Arte Povera, and a growing presence of Latin American artists, including politically charged and queer voices such as the Chilean Pedro Lemebel. Photography, video and installation crowd in beside painting and sculpture.

It changes often, and it's meant to feel restless — this is the part of the collection still being written, where the museum argues out loud about what art is for now. Don't try to see it all. Let something stop you. When you're ready, there's one last place to go — up and out — this way.

TRACK 063 · FLOOR 4 W-FOCUS 156 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Lygia Clark, *Bichos*

WHERE YOU ARE

Small geometric objects of hinged metal plates — folded, angular, looking like they want to be picked up and reshaped.

WHAT YOU SEE

Lygia Clark, the Brazilian pioneer of Neo-Concrete art, and her famous *Bichos* — "Critters" — of the late 1950s and sixties: flat metal shapes joined by hinges so they can be folded and refolded into endless three-dimensional configurations. They were made to be handled, manipulated, brought to life by the viewer's own hands.

LISTEN FOR

That was the radical idea — to break the artwork out of the frame and the pedestal and put it in your grip, making you a collaborator rather than a spectator. Clark went further still, toward art as something close to therapy and shared bodily experience. Her presence here is the museum stating its case out loud: that the story of modern art runs through São Paulo and Rio as surely as through Paris and New York. One final stop, right this way.

TRACK 064 · FLOOR 4 W-FOCUS 164 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Pedro Lemebel, *protest and performance*

WHERE YOU ARE

Most likely photographs, video or documents rather than a single object — the record of performances and actions, defiant and tender at once.

WHAT YOU SEE

Pedro Lemebel, the Chilean writer and artist who, with Francisco Casas, formed the collective *Las Yeguas del Apocalipsis* — "The Mares of the Apocalypse" — staging fearless queer performances in the dangerous last years of the Pinochet dictatorship and after. His presence here is part of the museum's deliberate opening toward Latin America and toward voices long pushed to the margins.

LISTEN FOR

This is what the contemporary floor is for — to widen the story of modern art beyond Europe, beyond the canvas, beyond the straight and the official. Lemebel made his own body and his words the work, insisting on dignity and desire under a regime that denied both. Set him against *Guernica* downstairs and you can see one continuous thread across the whole museum: art as a way of refusing to be silenced. The roof is waiting, just along here.

TRACK 065 · FLOOR 4 R-INTRO 162 WORDS · ~1 MIN

Out onto the roof

To finish, leave the old hospital and cross into the Nouvel building — the glass-and-steel wing with the great red lattice roof that the architect Jean Nouvel wrapped around the Sabatini block in 2005.

This is where the museum keeps much of its breathing room: the big temporary exhibitions, the library, the café in the covered courtyard, and — best of all to end on — the rooftop terraces, where contemporary sculpture sits in the open air under that red canopy, with one of the finest high views over the rooftops of Madrid. After hours inside Spain's hardest century, it's the right place to come up for light.

That's the collection, from the avant-garde's first dream to the art of right now. Whatever's currently up here changes by the season — so treat the roof as your full stop, catch your breath, and let the city back in. When you're ready, I'll see you back at the entrance for a last word.

TRACK 066 · CLOSING CLOSE 255 WORDS · ~2 MIN

Back out into Madrid

That's the century, more or less — from the hope of the avant-garde, through the scream of *Guernica*, into the long silence of the dictatorship and out into everything that came after. It's worth saying what makes this museum unusual. The Prado, up the road, is a treasure-house: the spoils of kings, gathered for pleasure. This place is something else. It's a museum that takes its own country's worst wound and keeps it on the wall, unhealed, on purpose — so that nobody gets to look away. That's why *Guernica* doesn't sit behind glass. You were meant to stand close enough to feel small in front of it.

You've walked the whole collection now — the avant-garde and the war down on Floor 2, the long grey aftermath and the Transition on Floor 1, and up here, the open present. Whatever's left to discover is in the Nouvel building across the way: the big temporary exhibitions, and the rooftop terraces, where there's open-air sculpture and one of the finest views in Madrid. It changes constantly; that's rather the point.

When you step back outside, you're in the corner of Madrid they call the art triangle — the Prado and the Thyssen are a short walk north, and Atocha station is right there if you're moving on. But give yourself a minute first. Sit in the Sabatini garden, or in the courtyard under Nouvel's red roof. A museum like this asks a lot of you. It's allowed to. Thank you for walking it with me.

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